



| WNHS PROCEDURE       |                                          |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------|
| MBU Search procedure |                                          |
| Scope (Staff):       | Mental health staff working in WNHS only |
| Scope (Area):        | WHGMH, Mother Baby Unit (MBU)            |

## 1. Aim

To ensure that patients, visitors and staff within the Mother and Baby Unit are provided with a safe environment.

## 2. Risk

Non-compliance with this policy will:

|                                        |                          |                                   |                                     |
|----------------------------------------|--------------------------|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Breach legislative requirements        | <input type="checkbox"/> | Impact on Patient Quality of Care | <input type="checkbox"/>            |
| Breach National/State/Mandatory Policy | <input type="checkbox"/> | Impact on Patient Safety          | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> |
| Breach professional standards          | <input type="checkbox"/> | Impact financial operations       | <input type="checkbox"/>            |
| Damage NMHS reputation                 | <input type="checkbox"/> | Impact on Staff Safety            | <input type="checkbox"/>            |
| Other                                  | <input type="checkbox"/> |                                   |                                     |
|                                        |                          |                                   |                                     |

## 3. Key Points

All patients' persons and property will be searched -

- On admission
- If placed under the [Mental Health Act 2014](#)
- If there is a likelihood of the person possessing item(s) which may be of harm to themselves and/or others
- Where there is evidence of clinical deterioration.

## 4. Process

Prior to admission

1. At the point of triage, all patients will be advised by the CNM/CNC of the requirements of a search process on admission along with other points of information such as valuables, clothing requirements etc. Staff will provide an explanation of the necessity to maintain a safe environment for all patients on the ward.

On Admission:

1. Verbal consent from the patient should be sought prior to a search being undertaken.

2. The use of an interpreter should be facilitated in the event of language/ communication issues.
3. A full explanation regarding the search will be given in a private area and the individual will be given the opportunity to hand in any potentially unsafe items.
4. Searches must be conducted in a sensitive manner, recognising that this may be a difficult and triggering process for patients.
5. The patient should be present for the search whenever possible and two nursing staff check and list property as part of this process
6. Nursing staff are responsible for contacting security if the risk assessment determines the need for their presence.
7. Items to be checked include (and are not limited to) toiletry bag, make up bags, cases and bags, pockets in clothing and shoes, baby/nappy bags, baby items, pram.
8. Items that will be removed routinely from all patients will include razors, medications, phone cords, glass, lighters, belts and straps on nappy bags i.e. Items that are easily accessed impulsively.
9. Following a clinical risk assessment, if the risk continues to be high then a decision will be made regarding the removal of items such as bras, shoe laces, hoodie cords, pens to ensure the safety of the patient. At this stage an appropriate level of nursing observation will be determined alongside the decision to remove items and recorded in the medical file.

**Search of patient's room and belongings will also occur when a patient is placed under the [Mental Health Act 2014](#)**

**If a search is made due to deterioration in mental state or a patient has been placed under the Mental Health Act, consideration will be made to a patient's observation level that correlates with the level of risk.**

### **CHECKING PROCEDURE FOR ALL PATIENTS**

1. All patients' property is checked and listed in the Property Book with the patient being present, wherever possible.
2. The shift coordinator and the allocated nurse will conduct the search.
3. The Property Book is signed by the patient with two staff members present during the checking of the patient's property. A copy of the form must be given to the patient.
4. If visitors bring in additional belongings another form needs to be completed and added to the original patient property form.
5. Items brought onto the unit by visitors must be inspected by the patient's nurse to ensure that the items do not pose a risk on the ward.
6. All nursing staff are to maintain an awareness of the potential for injury from sharps, etc., when conducting a check. Staff are advised to ask the patient if there is any risk before searching through property and look before touching.
7. An environmental check of the ward will be conducted once a day to identify any hazards or concerning items (including the presence of drugs and alcohol).
8. The environmental check will be recorded on the security checklist and will be undertaken by the AM & PM shift coordinators. The environment needs to be appraised for any obvious risk items i.e. knives, craft

- scissors, knitting needles etc. Staff will need to consider the ward milieu when considering risk and potential items of risk.
9. All communal areas as well as patient rooms are to be visually checked at this time.
  10. Patient areas must be searched in a sensitive manner, recognising that this may be a difficult and triggering process for patients.
  11. Removal and return of items dangerous to self and others. Items considered to present a risk must be stored in the patients' pigeon holes.
  12. These items can be given to a family member to take home for safekeeping.
  13. Items that are deemed safe can be stored in the patient's room.
  14. Illicit substances and illegal goods will be forwarded to security.
  15. Legal goods will be returned on discharge.
  16. For medications see [WNHS Patients Own Medication](#)
  17. Staff may clarify with security regarding the legality of goods.

This search is to be documented in the patient's integrated progress notes (PMR07). MHA forms 8A and 8B are to be completed.

#### Related internal policies, procedures and guidelines (if required)

[Women and Perinatal Mental Health Referral and Management Guideline](#)

[WNHS Patient's Own Medication](#)

[WNHS Applying the MHA 2014](#)

[NMHS Policy Search of Patients, Visitors and their Property](#)

#### References (if required)

[Mental Health Act 2014](#)

#### Useful resources

Integrated Progress Notes – PMR07

[Mental Health Act Forms 2014](#) MHA forms 8A and 8B

Property Book MH 149

|                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |              |            |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|------------|
| Keywords                                                                                          | Search, safety, mental health, property, belongings                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |              |            |
| Procedure Sponsor                                                                                 | Head of Department Mother Baby Unit/ Director of Psychiatry                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |              |            |
| Procedure Author                                                                                  | Coordinator of Nursing - Mental Health                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |              |            |
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| Endorsed by:                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Date:        |            |
| NSQHS Standards Applicable:                                                                       | <input type="checkbox"/>  Std 1: Clinical Governance<br><input type="checkbox"/>  Std 5: Comprehensive Care |                | <input type="checkbox"/>  Std 6: Communicating for Safety<br><input type="checkbox"/>  Std 8: Recognising and Responding to Acute Deterioration |              |            |
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The health impact upon Aboriginal people has been considered, and where relevant incorporated and appropriately addressed in the development of this policy.

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